The Yuan dynasty began to go into decline around the middle of the fourteenth century. A series of floods and droughts caused widespread rural distress, while major public works projects, such as extension of the Grand Canal to the capital Beijing, resulted in acute financial strain. As has been the case during several periods in Chinese history, peasant revolts broke out in several parts of the country and eventually found support even among the local elites and literati. These coalesced into a major movement to oust the Mongol dynasty as an ‘alien’ dispensation.

One of the leaders of the movement, Zhen Chongbi, formerly a Buddhist monk, led the assault on the capital. He established the Ming dynasty in 1368, but ruled from Nanjing. The Mongol forces continued to hold out in several regions of the country. Some retreated to their Mongolian homeland. Sichuan came under Ming rule in 1371 and Yunnan in 1382. It was during the military operations in Yunnan that Zheng He, a boy hailing from a Muslim family, was taken prisoner, castrated and attached to the retinue of the future Ming emperor with the reign name of Yongle, who was then in charge of the Beijing region. Eunuchs were a common feature throughout Chinese history. With no chance of raising a family, they were expected to be more loyal to the king than regular employees. They were the preferred guardians of the royal harem. They sometimes rose to powerful positions, and Zheng He was one such example.

Zheng He would be appointed admiral of the Chinese maritime expeditions, seven in number, from 1405 CE to 1435 CE . The itinerary for these voyages would typically cover South-East Asia, Sri Lanka and the Malabar coast. Later voyages were extended to Hormuz and Aden and to important ports on the Persian and West Asian coasts. There would be visits to Somalia and to the port of Malindi on the East African coast. There were also side trips while the main fleet remained anchored in Calicut. There is an account of a visit to Mecca by a squadron on the seventh and last voyage.

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Zhen Chongbi reigned as the first Ming emperor, Hongwu, from 1368 CE to